

Breast Self-Exam Guide

A simple monthly check to know your breasts better

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Lock of Hopes

This guide is for awareness only and does not replace medical advice or screening tests.

1. Why breast self-exams matter

- Many breast changes are harmless, but some can be early signs of cancer.
- Doing regular self-exams helps you notice what is normal for you, so you can spot changes earlier.
- Self-exams do not replace mammograms or clinical breast exams by a doctor. They are an extra way to stay aware.

If you notice any unusual change, talk to a doctor as soon as you can.

2. When to do a self-exam

- Do it **once a month**.
- If you have periods: choose the same time every month, ideally **3 to 5 days after your period ends**, when breasts are less tender.
- If you do not have periods (after menopause or hysterectomy): choose a **fixed date** every month, for example the 1st or 15th.

3. Step 1: Look in the mirror

Undress to the waist and stand in front of a mirror with good light.

1. Stand with your arms relaxed by your sides.
 - Look for changes in size, shape, or position of each breast.
 - Check if the skin looks swollen, dimpled, or puckered.
2. Raise both arms above your head.

- Look again for changes in the contour of the breasts or nipples.
- 3. Place your hands on your hips and gently press to tighten your chest muscles.
 - Look for any dimpling or pulling in of the skin or nipples.

If you see a new change that does not go away, note it and speak to a doctor.

4. Step 2: Feel your breasts while lying down

Lying down spreads the breast tissue more evenly, making it easier to feel. Lie on your back. Place a small pillow or folded towel under your right shoulder and put your right arm behind your head.

1. Use the **pads of the 3 middle fingers** of your left hand to examine your right breast.
2. Use small circular motions, about the size of a coin.
3. Use **three levels of pressure**:
 - Light: to feel the tissue just under the skin
 - Medium: to feel a bit deeper
 - Firm: to feel near the rib cage and chest wall
4. Follow a pattern so you cover the entire breast and armpit area, for example:
 - Vertical lines up and down
 - Or small circles moving from the nipple outward

Repeat the same steps on your left breast using your right hand.

5. Step 3: Feel your breasts in the shower

Some people find it easier to feel changes when the skin is wet and slippery.

- Raise one arm behind your head.
- With the other hand, use the same circular motions and pressure levels as above.

- Cover the whole breast and armpit area.

6. What is normal, what is not

Normal for many people

- Breasts that feel lumpy or uneven, especially before periods
- One breast slightly larger or shaped differently than the other

Changes to get checked by a doctor

- A new lump or thickening in the breast or underarm
- Any area that feels very different from the rest of the breast
- Skin dimpling or puckering
- Redness, scaling, or thickening of the nipple or breast skin
- Nipple turning inward or changing position
- Nipple discharge, especially if bloody or from one side only
- Swelling, warmth, or sudden change in size or shape
- Persistent breast or nipple pain on one side

7. When to see a doctor

Contact a doctor or breast clinic if:

- You find a new lump or area that feels different
- A change you noticed last month is still there
- You have nipple discharge, especially with blood
- You are simply worried about a change

Do not panic. Most breast changes are not cancer, but it is always safer to check.

8. Important reminder

- Breast self-exam is a tool for **awareness**, not a formal screening test.
- You may still need mammograms and clinical breast exams as recommended for your age and risk.

Talk to your doctor about what screening plan is right for you.